



Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

A MODERN HERITAGE
Murals and other artworks depicting the story of Lord Ram adorn the terminal at Maharishi Valmiki International Airport; (right) the three-storey Ayodhya Dham railway station

of Hindu revivalism, often innocent to its own ironies, they are calling it "the new Vatican" or, alternatively, "the Indian Mecca".

The Ayodhya story, as we see it in history and in today's evolving landscape, runs on two tracks. One relates to the practical world—the sort that can be captured by, say, tourism statistics and other material denominators. The other is in the conceptual terrain, or in this case, theological. And the two are intimately connected. The new Ram temple, which is both symbol and substance at once and thus mediates between the two, is the ground from which this dual layer of meaning can be excavated. Architecture is never an accident. It arises in a place—a specific topography—and expresses a relation to it. Temples rise up in spaces already seen as sacred: in the Agamic codes that govern temple-building, it's called *sthala purana*. By coming into being, architecture also modifies the landscape of its birth, much in the fashion of what biologists call 'the extended phenotype'. With religious architecture, that network of cause and effect appears in more concentrated form. In Ayodhya, the transformation is not merely physical. Consciously or otherwise, it attempts to recode the architecture of the Hindu mind itself. The nodal point of this network of transformation is a grand temple complex spread over 70 acres—radiating out from it axially will be many euphoric millions spread over India who will respond to its magnetic pull, and a city that's poised to boom as a consequence. Together, enough to constitute a revolution in cultural behaviour.

THE TRANSFORMATION IN AYODHYA IS NOT JUST PHYSICAL. CONSCIOUSLY OR OTHERWISE, IT RECODES THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE HINDU MIND ITSELF

NAYA AYODHYA

The main temple itself—380 feet east to west, 250 feet north to south, and 161 feet up to the *shikhara*—and its 13 auxiliary temples bring together features to make all manner of pilgrims comfortable in more ways than one. This goes beyond the ramps and lifts, the locker rooms and medical facilities. Southern pilgrims will recognise Mysuru sculptor Arun Yogiraj's granite-black idol for its stylistic elements and the Smarta tradition's Panchayatana design of smaller temples to four deities surrounding the main deity. Having Sabari and the boatman Guha in the 'rishi court'—along with the Brahmin saints associated with the Rama story—may sit well with those who look for overt symbols of caste egalitarianism. But the real renaissance effect is reserved for what's outside. The town on the banks of Sarayu was always replete with temples, each centuries old and each marking a milestone in Rama's life. Charming in the way old temple towns go—narrow lanes flanked by historic structures,